



XBOX PLAYTEST

Distribute Pre-Release Builds in
Retail to Iterate Faster

WHAT IS PLAYTEST?

Playtest lets you distribute pre-release game builds directly to real players in the retail sandbox - without certification, without a store page, without an entitlement.

- Use builds from any Partner Center branch*
- Customer Groups (MSA) and (soon) invite tokens
- Players install via a secure deep link
- Content available in the Library for authorized players (soon).
- Build updates do not require recreating the playtest or re-invite players.

* Uploaded After April 15,2026

WHAT YOU CAN DO TODAY

Private Preview -- available now for selected studios

- Create a Playtest in Partner Center
- Use any build -- packages are encrypted and licensed independently
- Manage Your Audience via audience groups via Partner Center
 - add and remove user from existing groups
- Schedule a Playtest -- pick a start and end date/time
- Publish a Playtest -- no cert, no store page required
- Share a Deep Link -- testers install via msxbox:// URI
- Iterate -- update package or dates and republish
- Shut Down -- end a playtest cleanly; ~15 minutes to full teardown

HOW TO CREATE A PLAYTEST



Same retail pipeline as your shipped game. Packages are encrypted and licensed independently -- no risk to your GA product.

1

Upload a package

Locate the package for uploading

Package location

Confirm the location of the package path

Additional details

Destination

Select a destination and market

2

Create new playtest

Enter details

Basic information

Playtest name

Enter a unique name; testers will see this

Playtest description

Include a description about your product

Playtest type

Private

Start date

mm / dd / yyyy

time

00

3

Create new playtest

Enter details

Select package

Build

Package name

GXPTestPublisher.FlightingTeamUnPub

PC

Audience

Group For Jerry

Eddie's third test group for playtest

Group For Jerry

Joerossi_test_group

KushGroup1

4

Share your playtest

Copy the link below to share the playtest with your testers

msxbox://playtest/?productid=2SDT4X91K...

5

Share deep link

msxbox://game/?productid={ID}&private=true

6

Testers install and play

Playtest Demo

Install

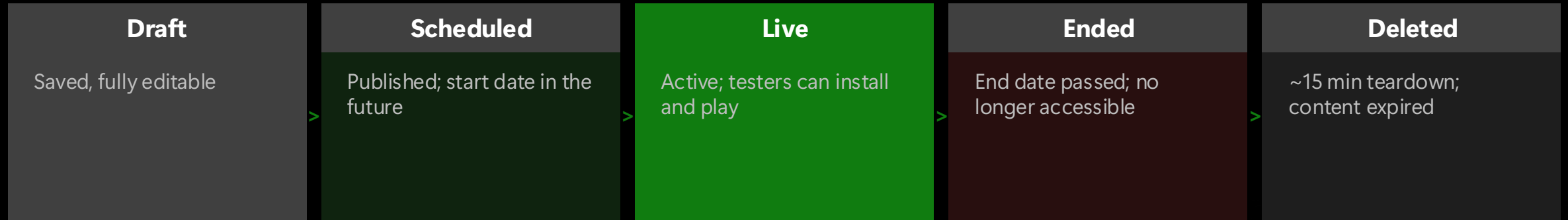
Information

About

Release date

5/16/2026

PLAYTEST LIFECYCLE



At any point: Edit and Republish -- swap package, extend dates, or change audience without recreating.

Note: If publish fails, current path is delete and recreate. Error recovery improvement is on the roadmap.

PLAYTEST VS. OTHER OPTIONS

	Private Audience	Package Flighting	Xbox Playtest
GA product required?	Yes	Yes	No
Cert required?	Conditional	10K+ users	10K+ users only
Pre-GA use?	No	No	Yes
Multiple simultaneous?	No	Limited	Yes
Audience management	Customer Groups	Customer Groups	Customer Group **
Lifecycle coverage	Pre-public only	Post-public only	Full lifecycle

** Additional audience management capabilities later this year

WHAT TO KNOW GOING IN

We want to be upfront about the constraints in Private Preview:

PC only

Gen8/9 consoles on roadmap, ETA Spring CY27

Deep link only

No store discovery; testers install via direct link

Library integration not yet available

Builds don't appear in player's Library (coming)

Audience >10K requires cert

Same rule as Private Audience

No crash dumps or analytics built in

On the roadmap, Fall CY26

PublishFailed = delete and recreate

Error recovery improvement planned

One installed playtest per product

Users can switch between playtests; only one install at a time

ROADMAP

COMING

Library Integration

Builds appear in player's Library -- no deep link needed

COMING

Token-Based Enrollment

Flexible invite tokens (similar to Steam release override tokens)

COMING

Insiders Program Integration

Improved audience management at scale

PLANNED

Analytics and Crash Collection

Build-level telemetry and crash dump collection

PLANNED

Feedback

In-context surveys, ratings, and bug reports from testers

PLANNED

Xbox console support

Support for Gen8/9 + Helix

GETTING STARTED

Prerequisites

- Partner Center access with SellerID enrolled for Playtest
- A build ready to upload (any pre-release package)
- Audience Groups set up in GMS (we can help with this)
- Xbox Live Service Config published (set embargo on features as needed)

Your first playtest

1. Create or identify a product in Partner Center
2. Upload your build
3. Create a Playtest -- set title and dates
4. Assign package + audience
5. Confirm Service Config publish and Embargo
6. Publish
7. Share the deep link with your testers

Your first playtest typically takes under 15 minutes once prerequisites are in place. We will work with you on enrollment.

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

Q: Do I need a base game or published product first?

A: No. Playtest works independently of GA product state.

Q: Will my playtest build be discoverable in the Xbox Store?

A: Not currently. Access is via deep link only -- library integration is coming.

Q: Does Xbox Live work in Playtest?

A: Yes -- fully supported in retail. Recommend setting an embargo on your Service Config if sharing with your base game.

Q: Do I have to specify platform support to playtest on that platform?

A: No -- e.g. you can playtest a PC build without declaring PC support publicly in the store.

Q: How long does it take to shut down a playtest?

A: ~15 minutes. Content expires, availability resets.

Q: Can we run multiple playtests at the same time?

A: Yes -- users will need to update their build when switching between playtests.

Q: Does Playtest affect our existing GA product or Xbox App?

A: No. Playtest is completely additive and separate from your GA product.

QUESTIONS? LET'S TALK.

